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EARLY IN 1932, with graduation a few months off, I faced the same question that gnaws at all college seniors: What do I do with the rest of my life?

It's easy to look back now and say the answer had been inside me for a long time. I suppose it had, but I still couldn't say aloud, even to myself, that I wanted to be an actor.

The dream had probably taken root that week of Thanksgiving vacation during my freshman year when we were waiting for the student strike to begin. Margaret's parents took us to see a touring company's production of *Journey's End*, a tragedy set in World War I that focused on the emotions of a weary, emotionally bruised military officer, Captain Stanhope. I was drawn to the stage that night as if it were a magnet, astonished by the magic of an ordinary man convincing an audience that he was someone else.

Once again fate intervened—as if God was carrying out His plan with my name on it. Just as a new teacher with a talent for teaching high school students how to act had arrived in Dixon High just as I got there, Eureka had hired a new English professor who had a deep love—and talent—for teaching dramatics. Her name was Ellen Marie Johnson and she treated acting as seriously as B. J. Frazer.

After taking over as faculty advisor for theater arts after-school activities, she increased the number of student productions and I began trying out for all the plays. One of the plays she staged was *Journey's End*, and when I won the part of Captain Stanhope, I was in heaven.

Miss Johnson organized a drama society that allowed students who were interested in dramatics to work together